National Science Foundation

One-page brief

Priority: 16 of 33 (score 3.0). **FY2026 outlays:** $8.1B (USAspending). **As of:** 2026-10-27. Public data only.

Bottom line

NSF is a grant maker with excellent public award data. Fraud risks are duplicate funding of the same research across agencies, SBIR award mills, and undisclosed conflicts. It is a cheap addition to the cross-agency SBIR screen and a good place to test text-similarity methods.

Exposure

- $8.1B in outlays in FY2026.
- GAO found 842 of 10,570 SBIR/STTR awardees (almost 8%) had four or more fraud risk indicators and about $445M in possibly duplicative awards across agencies (2024).

Public data we can use

- **NSF Award Search:** every award with abstract, PI and institution.
- **SBIR.gov** award data; **NIH RePORTER** for cross-agency overlap.
- **NSF OIG** reports and investigations.

Detection plays

1. **Duplicate research:** near-identical abstracts funded by NSF and other agencies.
2. **Award mills:** firms or PIs with many awards and little output.
3. **Network links** to excluded parties or settled cases.

First prototype

Use NSF as the test bed for the cross-agency duplicate-award screen.

Limits

Some topical overlap is legitimate; leads need program officer review.

Geodesic Solutions: geodesic.pro *Contact: Steve Taylor, Managing Partner: taylor@geodesic.pro*

Who to take it to

NSF OIG, NSF SBIR/STTR program office.

Sources

- GAO-24-105470: SBIR/STTR fraud vulnerabilities
- NSF Award Search
- USAspending agency profiles (FY2026 outlays)